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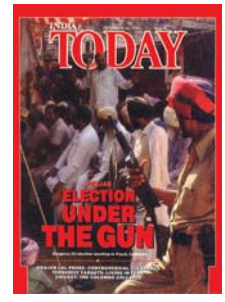
EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

Anyone who believes state elections are dull and predictable should look closely at Punjab's upcoming polls. In the fray are a 79-year-old titular maharaja, a former standup comedian, a 94-year-old former chief minister who won his first election 65 years ago, and a dark horse who outmanoeuvred a cricketer-turned-TV host-turned politician to become the CM candidate. They represent the four sides of the state's first multi-cornered contest in recent years.

With 117 assembly constituencies, Punjab has fewer seats than eastern Uttar Pradesh. Yet the stakes here are among the highest in the five states going to elections this month. There are several reasons. Punjab is a frontier state that shares a 553-kilometre boundary with Pakistan. Memories of a Pakistan-supported militancy that lasted over a decade, from the 1980s to the 1990s, are still fresh. Of late, there have been persistent attempts by Pakistan's deep state to revive militancy, some of which have included sending drones packed with weapons and explosives.

Punjab was more recently the epicentre of an unprecedented 12-month-long farmers' agitation that began two months after the central government brought in three farm laws in September 2020. The stir ended a year later in November 2021 when the government withdrew the laws.

In another political drama late last year, Punjab CM Amarinder Singh was replaced by a relatively unknown Congressman, Charanjit Singh Channi. Differences over the farm laws saw the Shiromani Akali Dal part ways with its alliance partner of 23 years, the BJP, in 2020. The Akalis, besides relying on their traditional Jat Sikh vote bank, have teamed up with the BSP in the hope of getting a share of the Dalit vote. Amarinder Singh, meanwhile, has broken away from the Congress to float his own Punjab Lok Congress. The BJP, eager for a Sikh face after SAD's exit, has partnered with him. The Aam Aadmi Party, which made its debut in the state in 2017, has projected a former standup comic, Bhagwant Mann, as its CM candidate. Even the 22 farm unions who got the government to roll back the farm laws have floated their own party to contest the election. This bewildering array of formations and multi-cornered contests means that the possibility of a hung assembly this time around is very real. And that's what makes this election so contentious.



September 30, 1985



February 28, 1997

Punjab has three major regions—Malwa, Doaba and Majha. AAP has a base in the largest, Malwa, but needs seats from the Doaba and Majha regions to cross the 59-seat halfway mark. The Congress faces anti-incumbency, though Channi's candidature as CM gives them a fighting chance. Being a Dalit, Channi is relying on cornering a large share of the 32 per cent Dalit vote. They are, however, divided too. The SAD under Sukhbir Badal might have lost the last election but has managed to retain its vote bank. Badal is counting on promises of development to see his party through this election. His father, the nonagenarian Parkash Singh Badal, is fighting his 13th assembly election, because every seat counts. Issues like the rampant drug addiction among the state's youth and the 2015 desecration of the Guru Granth Sahib continue to be emotive. The BJP-Amarinder Singh alliance hopes to consolidate Hindu and moderate Sikh voters. The party is also building up its base among the Mazhabi Sikh community.

Any one of three scenarios could unfold when results are declared on March 10. The first—a hung assembly with none of the four formations getting a clear majority. The second—a decisive vote in favour of one of the opposition formations, and the third—a return of the ruling Congress.

Whoever wins will have the unenviable task of fixing an underperforming state. Punjab was once one of India's most prosperous states. Today, its finances are in a mess. The state's debt is now 43.7 per cent of GSDP (it was more than half the previous fiscal on account of the lower GSDP), and repayment is expected to take up 29 per cent of the state budget. The state's expected expenditure of Rs 1.68 lakh crore this year is nearly double its projected revenue of Rs 95,263 crore. The per capita income of Rs 1.15 lakh is lower than the national average of Rs 1.16 lakh. The state spends just Rs 869 per person on capital expenditure against a national average of Rs 3,509, and Rs 6,981 on social sector expenditure against a national average of Rs 8,962. Agriculture is stagnant, unable to break out of the two-crop cycle of wheat and paddy.

More than half the state's young people, born after the 1990s, have no memory of militancy. The real worry for them today is the lack of jobs. Industries that deserted the state during militancy have not returned. Because of this, thousands of the state's youth have been migrating to the West in search of better opportunities.

Group Editorial Director (Publishing) Raj Chengappa, Group Photo Editor Bandeep Singh and Senior Editor Anilesh S. Mahajan recently travelled to Punjab. It is a state, we discovered, all three were born in. They interviewed and photographed all four leaders of Punjab's major parties on the campaign trail to put together our cover story, 'The Battle of the Sardars'. They got a sense of what these leaders are promising the electorate and why this battle is crucial for the state. Given the plot twists and turns and the bewildering star cast, this is one potboiler no one really knows the outcome of. The trouble will begin if there is a hung assembly. Who will ally with whom to form a government, if at all? They all hate each other. But, then, anything is possible in Indian politics.



(Aroon Purie)